

WOLFE

BY DORIAN WOLFE

THE PLAYBOOK

THE CONVERSATION PLAYBOOK

How to take any conversation from "hey" to genuinely connected, and what to say when it stalls.

DORIAN WOLFE · CALM. DIRECT. REAL.

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Dorian Wolfe shares general communication advice for adults. It is not therapy and no result is guaranteed. Always respect other people's boundaries and consent.

WHY CONVERSATIONS DIE

You match. You text. The first few messages go fine, then it slowly fades. Or you sit across from someone on a date and run out of things to say.

It feels like a personality problem. It is not. It is a **skills problem**, and skills can be learned.

Conversations die for three reasons:

- | | |
|------------------------|--|
| Interview mode | You fire question after question and share nothing. It feels like a job interview. |
| Surface level | You stay on facts (work, weather, weekend) and never reach feelings or stories. |
| Fear of silence | You panic at a pause and say something forgettable, or nothing at all. |

This playbook fixes all three with simple, repeatable tools. Read it once, then practise one chapter a day.

THE 3-LAYER RULE

Every conversation has three layers. Most people never leave the first.

Layer 1: Facts

"Where did you grow up?" "What do you do?"
Safe, easy, forgettable.

Layer 2: Feelings

"What did you like about growing up there?"
"What do you enjoy about your job?" This is where she lights up.

Layer 3: Meaning

"What did that teach you?" "Why does it matter to you?" This is where real connection happens.

Psychologist Arthur Aron and colleagues found in 1997 that gradually deeper, mutual sharing can create closeness even between strangers. The key words are **gradually** and **mutual**. You go deeper only as fast as she is comfortable, and you share too.

YOUR RULE

Spend a minute in Layer 1, then ask one Layer 2 question. Only go to Layer 3 when the mood allows it.

ECHO, DIG, SHARE

A simple loop that keeps any conversation moving.

Echo	Repeat her key word with curiosity. She says "I just got back from Lisbon." You say "Lisbon! What took you there?"
Dig	Ask about the feeling or the reason. "What was the best part?" "Why that city?"
Share	Offer a short story or opinion of your own. "I have always wanted to go. I got lost in Istanbul once, completely lost."

Then loop back to Echo. This loop alone turns a Q&A into a conversation.

EXAMPLE

She: I started pottery classes last month.

You: Pottery! (Echo) What made you try it? (Dig)

She: I needed something that was not a screen.

You: I get that. I spend all day at a laptop and I started cooking for the same reason. (Share) What is the hardest part so far?

ESCAPE INTERVIEW MODE

If you ask three questions in a row without sharing, you are interviewing her. The fix is the **1:1 rule**: for every question you ask, give one piece of yourself.

INTERVIEW MODE (BAD)

✗ "Where do you work?" "Do you like it?" "How long?" "Any siblings?"

CONVERSATION MODE (GOOD)

What do you do? ... Oh nice, I am in [field]. I actually fell into it by accident. How did you end up there?

QUICK TEST

Look at your last 3 messages. If all three end with a question mark, add a statement about you.

30 BETTER QUESTIONS

Keep these in your notes app. Ask them naturally, not like a checklist.

EASY (LAYER 1 TO 2)

- 1 What is the best thing you have eaten recently?
- 2 What is a small thing that always makes your day better?
- 3 If you had a free Saturday, what would you do?
- 4 What was the last show or book you could not stop?
- 5 What is your go-to comfort food?
- 6 What is the best trip you have ever taken?
- 7 What is something you are weirdly good at?
- 8 Are you a morning or night person, and how bad is it?
- 9 What is on your playlist you would be embarrassed by?
- 10 What would your perfect Sunday look like?

WARM (LAYER 2)

- 11 What was your favourite thing about growing up where you did?
- 12 What is something you are proud of that no one asks about?
- 13 Who has influenced you the most?
- 14 What do you do when you need to recharge?
- 15 What did you want to be when you were ten?
- 16 What is the best advice you have ever received?
- 17 What kind of people do you feel most yourself around?
- 18 What are you looking forward to this year?
- 19 What is a skill you wish you had?

20 What is the happiest memory that comes to mind right now?

DEEP (LAYER 3, USE SPARINGLY)

21 What is something you used to believe that you do not anymore?

22 What do you wish people understood about you?

23 When do you feel most alive?

24 What is a risk you took that changed things?

25 What are you still figuring out?

26 What is something you are afraid to say out loud?

27 What does a good relationship look like to you?

28 What would you do differently if no one was watching?

29 What do you value more as you get older?

30 What is a moment that shaped who you are?

IMPORTANT

Always share your own answer too. Deep questions only work when it is a trade, not an interrogation.

WHAT TO SAY WHEN SHE OPENS UP

This is where most people freeze. She shares something personal and you say "oh, that is rough" or change the subject. Use the **ARAS** steps:

A: Acknowledge	"That sounds like it was really hard." / "That must have felt amazing."
R: Reflect	Say back what you heard. "So you moved alone at 22 and had to figure it out."
A: Ask	"What was that like for you?" / "How did you get through it?"
S: Share	A short, relevant moment from your life. Keep it brief and return the focus to her.

EXAMPLE

She: My dad was sick last year. It was a rough time.

You: I am sorry, that sounds exhausting. (Acknowledge) You were looking after everyone while holding it together. (Reflect) How are you doing now? (Ask)

- ✗ Do not try to fix it ("You should just...").
- ✗ Do not one-up her ("Oh, mine was worse").
- ✗ Do not rush to a joke to escape the discomfort.
- ✗ Do not change the subject.

5 WAYS TO BEAT AWKWARD SILENCE

A pause is not a failure. Two seconds of silence feels like ten to you and almost nothing to her. If it still feels stuck, use one of these:

- 1. Breathe and smile** Do nothing for three seconds. Comfortable people tolerate silence.
- 2. The callback** Return to something she said earlier. "Wait, earlier you mentioned [thing]. Tell me more."
- 3. Observe the moment** "This place has great lighting." / "That is the loudest espresso machine I have ever heard."
- 4. The pivot question** "Can I switch topics? What is something you are excited about this month?"
- 5. The honest line** "I lost my train of thought. Your turn to pick a topic." Honesty charms people.

PREPARE IN ADVANCE

Pick two callbacks and one pivot question before every conversation. Confidence is mostly preparation.

"TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF"

She says "so, tell me about yourself" and your mind goes blank. Use the **Present, Past, Passion** formula. Aim for 20 to 30 seconds, then hand it back.

Present	What you do now, in one line.
Past	One interesting thing that shaped you.
Passion	Something you love, with energy.

EXAMPLE

I run a small [business/role] (Present). I grew up in [place], which is why I am obsessed with [thing] (Past). Right now I am trying to get better at [hobby], badly, but I love it (Passion). What about you?

- ✗ Do not recite your CV.
- ✗ Do not brag or list achievements.
- ✗ Do not talk for more than 30 seconds.
- ✗ Always end by asking her back.

FROM TEXTING TO TALKING

A good chat over text should lead to a real meeting. Do not stay in text-land for weeks.

Rule of 3 days

After about 3 days of good chatting, suggest meeting.

Be specific

"Coffee Thursday at 6?" beats "We should hang out sometime."

Offer two options

"Thursday or Saturday?" makes saying yes easy.

Accept a no gracefully

"No worries, take care." Never argue or guilt-trip.

I am enjoying this. Want to continue it over coffee Thursday or Saturday?

END ON A HIGH

The last 30 seconds are what people remember. Leave while it is still good.

I have to run, but I loved this. Let us do it again soon.

In person

I had a great time. Same again next week?

After a date

I have to head off. Let us pick this up tomorrow.

Over text

Do not wait for the energy to drop. Ending early leaves her wanting more, in the healthiest way.

10 CONVERSATION KILLERS

- ✗ Interrogating with question after question.
- ✗ Talking only about yourself.
- ✗ Checking your phone while she talks.
- ✗ Interrupting to finish her sentence.
- ✗ Giving advice she did not ask for.
- ✗ Complaining about exes, work or the world.
- ✗ Fake agreement. Be honest, politely.
- ✗ Over-complimenting. One genuine compliment beats ten.
- ✗ Dropping a heavy topic too early.
- ✗ Trying to impress instead of connect.

7-DAY PRACTICE PLAN

Skills come from practice. Do one task a day with anyone: coworker, barista, friend.

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|--------------|--|
| Day 1 | Echo: repeat the key word of what someone says and ask about it. |
| Day 2 | Ask one Layer 2 question in a normal conversation. |
| Day 3 | Use the 1:1 rule. Share before you ask. |
| Day 4 | Practise ARAS with a friend who shares something. |
| Day 5 | Tolerate a 3-second silence on purpose. |
| Day 6 | Practise your Present, Past, Passion answer out loud. |
| Day 7 | Invite someone (a friend, a match) to a specific plan. |

FINAL NOTE

Conversation is a way of being curious about another person. No script replaces that. Respect her boundaries, accept a no, and keep improving. Good luck.

BE CALM.
BE CURIOUS.
BE REAL.

— Dorian Wolfe